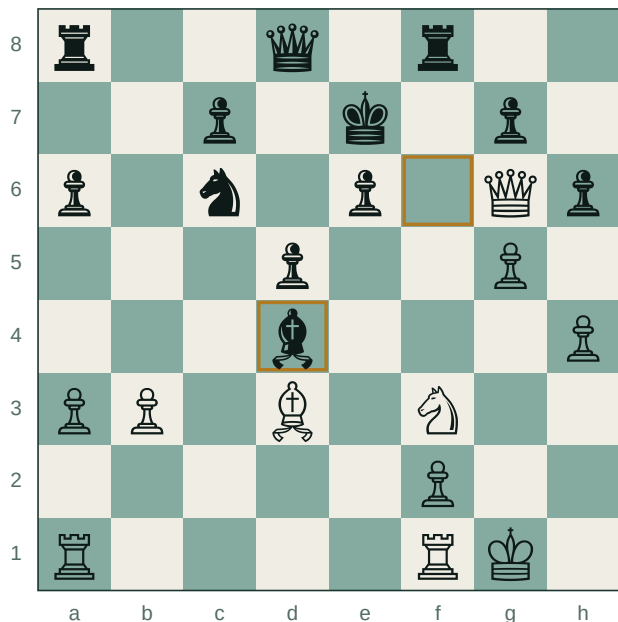


Capture the defender: White, move 25

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 24...Bxd4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

25. Nxd4 Nxd4 26. Qxg7+ Rf7 27. Qxd4

25.Nxd4 The knight captures the bishop on d4. Recorded reply: **25...Nxd4**.

26.Qxg7+ Check restricts Black to 3 legal replies here. From g7 it attacks king on e7, rook on f8 and knight on d4. Recorded reply: **26...Rf7**.

27.Qxd4 The queen captures the knight on d4.

At the end, nominal material is White 27 / Black 24 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +4. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +4: the balance goes from -1 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on e7. Geometrically undefended: knight on c6. Check for tactical protection.